MEDIEVAL MOUNTED WARRIORS

The state of military technology in the medieval period ensured that, under most circumstances, the armoured fighting man on horseback was a decisive figure in warfare. But these heavy cavalrymen, although all fighting with lance and sword, were varied in their military organization. In the course of the Crusades, which established and sustained Christian kingdoms in the Muslim-dominated eastern Mediterranean from 1098 to 1291, orders of warrior-monks were founded to fight a holy war. Their Muslim enemies were equally inspired by religious enthusiasm, as well as by more practical motives. At the other extreme, bands of mercenaries led by faithless knights fought cynically for personal profit, at times laying regions of Europe to waste.

KNIGHT TEMPLAR

Founded by crusader knights based in the Temple of Solomon in Jerusalem in 1119, the Templars were the first monastic military order. Like monks, they lived by a rule of poverty, chastity, and obedience, but they also developed into an elite military force. Numbering around 300 "brother knights", the Templars were recognized as the best disciplined element in the crusader armies. They were also the wealthiest, thanks to the pious donations they received from all over Christian Europe. This allowed them to build impressive castles and employ substantial numbers of foot soldiers. The Templars fought courageously in defence of the crusader states to the very end. Their Grand Master, William of Beaujeu, was among those killed when the port of Acre, the last crusader stronghold in the Holy Land, fell to the Egyptian Mamluks in 1291.

The Templars' wealth eventually proved their undoing. In 1307 the impecunious French King Philip IV arrested all the Templars within his lands, charging them with heretical and obscene practices. Pope Clement V suppressed the order in 1312 and the last Templar Grand Master, Jacques de Molay, was burned at the stake in 1314.

> "...THEY APPEAR GENTLER THAN LAMBS, YET FIERCER THAN LIONS."
>
> **ST BERNARD OF CLAIRVAUX** PRAISING THE TEMPLARS IN THE EARLY YEARS OF THE ORDER

TEUTONIC KNIGHT

The military order of the Teutonic Knights was founded by German crusaders at Acre in the Kingdom of Jerusalem in 1198. It is most famous for its crusades in Europe. From 1226 the order waged a long, brutal war to subjugate the pagan Prussians, establishing its own state in Prussia. In the 14th century its annual campaigns against pagan Lithuania were joined by knights from across Europe. The order was also at odds with its Catholic neighbours, the Poles. When the Lithuanians, now Christianized, and the Poles united against the Teutonic Knights, they crushed them at the battle of Grunwald in 1410. The order never recovered from this defeat and gradually lost all its Baltic territories, although it survived – in name at least – until 1809.

Rondel dagger
This style of dagger was popular with knights across northern Europe.

Crusader helmet
The flat-topped "pot helm", with a hinged visor covering the face, was the standard headgear of Christian knights in the Crusades.



Templar castle
In Portugal the Order of Christ took over the Templar headquarters at Tomar, where it preserved the tradition of warrior-monks.